Chapter 50 — Notification Center / Inbox

> **Part VI — Lifecycle, Background & Platform** · Complexity: **Standard** (≥25 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 49 (FCM/push), Ch 51 (notification permission), Ch 3 (SSOT/ Room), Ch 32 (sync), Ch 52 (deep links). Pairs with Ch 46 (FGS notifications), Ch 6 (UI state).
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** both halves of "notifications" — the **system notifications** (channels, grouping, styles, actions, lock-screen) shown in the status bar, and the **in-app notification inbox** (a persistent, synced list of messages the user can read, mark read, and act on).

50.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

"Notifications" means two related systems that teams often conflate:

1. **System notifications** — the OS status-bar/drawer notifications, governed by **channels** (Android 8+), importance, grouping, styles (BigText, Inbox, Messaging), actions, and lock-screen visibility. These are **ephemeral** (dismissed = gone) and fully user-controllable (per-channel settings).
2. **In-app notification inbox** — a **persistent, synced list** inside the app (bell icon → list of order updates, messages, promos) that survives dismissal, shows read/unread, and is the source of truth for "what did I get." This is a normal **offline-first data feature** (SSOT + sync, Ch 3/32), not a system-notification concern.

The problems arise when these aren't designed together:

- **Treating the system notification as the record.** Once dismissed, it's gone — if there's no inbox, the user permanently loses the message. The **inbox** (persisted, synced) is the record; the system notification is a transient *alert*.
- **Channel mismanagement.** No channels (required Android 8+), one giant channel (user can't tune), or wrong importance → users disable *all* notifications. Channels created late or renamed badly confuse settings.
- **Notification spam & no grouping.** Posting many individual notifications instead of **grouping** (summary + children) floods the drawer and gets the app muted.
- **Inconsistent rendering.** Scattered `NotificationCompat` calls across the codebase → inconsistent styling, missing actions, duplicate ids, lock-screen leaks. A central **Notifier** is needed.
- **Read-state divergence.** Tapping a system notification doesn't mark the inbox item read; reading in-app doesn't dismiss the system notification; read state doesn't sync across devices (Ch 32).
- **Permission (Android 13+).** Without `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` (Ch 51), system notifications are silently suppressed — but the inbox should still work.

The architecture: build a central **Notifier** that owns **channels** (created at startup, correct importance), consistent **styles/actions/grouping**, lock-screen visibility, and ids; model the **inbox as an offline-first feature** (Room SSOT + sync, Ch 3/32) with read/unread and actions; **link the two** (tapping a system notification deep-links into the app and marks the inbox item read, Ch 52; in-app read optionally cancels the system notification; read state syncs, Ch 32);

and gate system display on **notification permission** (Ch 51) while keeping the inbox functional regardless. This chapter is about **a coherent notification experience across the status bar and an in-app inbox**.

Three practical use cases

1. **StreamCart order update.** Push (Ch 49) → inbox row persisted (SSOT) + system notification posted (right channel, deep-link action, Ch 52); tapping marks read and navigates; read syncs across devices.
2. **Grouped chat messages.** Multiple messages → **grouped** notification (summary + per- message children, Messaging style); inbox shows the conversation; reading in-app cancels the system group.
3. **Promotions channel.** A separate low-importance "Promotions" channel the user can mute independently without losing transactional notifications.

Why this is architectural

The notification experience spans **push (Ch 49)**, **persistence/sync (Ch 3/32)**, **deep links (Ch 52)**, **permissions (Ch 51)**, and **UI (Ch 6)** — and the key insight (system notification = transient alert; inbox = durable record; keep them in sync) is a design decision that affects reliability, UX, and user trust (spam → muting).

50.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Post consistent system notifications (channels, styles, actions, grouping, lock-screen).
F2	Maintain a persistent, synced in-app inbox (read/unread, actions).
F3	Link the two: tap → deep-link + mark read; in-app read → optionally cancel system notif; read syncs.
F4	Group related notifications; avoid spam.
F5	Gate system display on permission (Ch 51); inbox works regardless.
F6	Respect per-channel user settings and consent/preferences.

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Policy
Durability	Inbox persists (SSOT); system notifications are transient alerts.
Consistency	Central Notifier; one style/id scheme; read state in sync.
UX / trust	Grouping, correct importance; no spam → avoid muting.
Privacy	Lock-screen sensitivity (public/private); no PII leak (Ch 28).
Resilience	Works without notification permission (inbox); offline-first inbox.

Scope

- **In scope:** notification channels/groups/importance, styles (BigText/Inbox/ Messaging/BigPicture), actions + `PendingIntent`, grouping (summary + children), lock-screen visibility, central Notifier, in-app inbox (Room SSOT + sync, read/unread), linking system ↔ inbox (deep link + read sync), permission gating, channel settings deep-link.
- **Out of scope:** push transport (Ch 49), permission request UX (Ch 51), deep-link routing detail (Ch 52), sync algorithm (Ch 32), SSOT internals (Ch 3), FGS notifications (Ch 46).

Assumptions & constraints

- `minSdk 24`; channels required Android 8+ (`targetSdk` enforces); Android 13+ notification permission. `NotificationCompat`, Room, WorkManager/sync, Compose. Inbox is an offline-first feature; system notifications are ephemeral and user-controllable.

50.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **System notification = transient alert; inbox = durable record.** This is the core mental model. The status-bar notification *alerts* the user now and can be dismissed; the **inbox** (persisted in Room, synced, Ch 3/32) is the authoritative list of what the user received and its read state. Design both and keep them consistent.
- **Channels (Android 8+, mandatory).** Every notification belongs to a **channel** with a user-controllable **importance** (HIGH/DEFAULT/LOW/MIN), sound, vibration, and lock-screen behavior. Create channels **at app startup** (idempotent), one per *category* (Transactional, Chat, Promotions, …) so users can tune/mute each independently. **You cannot change a channel's importance after creation** (the user owns it) — so choose categories thoughtfully and don't over-split.
- **Channel groups** organize many channels in settings (e.g., "Account A" vs "Account B" for multi-account, Ch 42).
- **Styles & content.** `NotificationCompat` with `BigTextStyle` (long text), `InboxStyle` (list), `MessagingStyle` (chat — the correct style for conversations, shows avatars/sender), `BigPictureStyle` (image). Set a small icon, content title/ text, timestamp, and a **content** **`PendingIntent`** (deep link, Ch 52) + **action buttons** (`PendingIntent`s: Reply/Mark read/Archive).
- **Grouping (avoid spam).** Related notifications share a **group key**; post a **summary** notification plus children. The system collapses them into one group in the drawer. Essential for chat/updates — posting N separate notifications floods the drawer and gets the app muted.
- **Lock-screen visibility & privacy.** `setVisibility(PUBLIC/PRIVATE/SECRET)` and a **public version** (`setPublicVersion`) control what shows on the lock screen; keep sensitive content off it (Ch 28). Respect the channel's lock-screen setting too.
- **PendingIntent correctness (Ch 49/52).** Content/action intents use `FLAG_IMMUTABLE` (Android 12+), explicit intents (your own component / a deep-link `Uri`), and distinct request codes per notification; tapping routes via deep links (Ch 52) into the right screen *and* marks the inbox item read.
- **Inbox as offline-first (Ch 3/29/32).** The inbox is a Room table (`InboxItem{id, type, title, body, deepLink, isRead, createdAt, account}`), written when a push arrives (Ch 49) and reconciled by **sync** (Ch 32) so it's consistent across devices and survives reinstalls (server-backed). The UI (Ch 6) observes it; **read state is a synced field** (mark read locally → sync up → other devices reflect it).
- **Linking the two systems:**

    - Push (Ch 49) → **write inbox item (SSOT)** *and* **post system notification** (same id/deep link).
    - **Tap system notification** → deep-link (Ch 52) → screen + **mark inbox item read** → **cancel the system notification**.
    - **Read in-app** → optionally **cancel** the corresponding system notification (`NotificationManager.cancel(id)`); **sync read state** (Ch 32).
- **Permission gating (Ch 51).** On Android 13+, no `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` → system notifications are suppressed, but the **inbox still receives and shows items** (push data still arrives, Ch 49). So the inbox is the resilient channel; design it to work regardless of permission.

Core insight: **treat the system notification as a transient alert and the in-app inbox (Room SSOT + sync) as the durable record; render all system notifications through one central Notifier that owns channels (by category, created at startup), consistent styles/ actions/grouping, and lock-screen privacy; link the two so a tap deep-links and marks read and in-app reads cancel/sync, with read state synced across devices; and keep the inbox functional even without notification permission** — so the user never loses a message and never gets spammed into muting the app.

50.4 High-Level Architecture


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Components & ownership

- **Notifier** centralizes system-notification rendering (channels/styles/grouping/ privacy/ids).
- **Inbox** (Room SSOT + sync) is the durable record with read state.
- **Linking** (deep link, mark-read, cancel, read-sync) keeps the two consistent.
- **Permission** gates system display only; the inbox is resilient.

Direction: push → inbox (durable) + system alert (transient) → tap/read links them → read state syncs.

50.5 Detailed Component Design


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Component	Responsibility
`Notifier`	one place to build/post/cancel system notifications (channel/style/group/privacy/PendingIntent)
`ChannelInitializer`	create channels+groups at startup (idempotent)
`InboxRepository`	Room-backed inbox (SSOT) + read state + sync (Ch 3/32)
Inbox UI	observe + render + mark read (Ch 6)

50.6 End-to-End Data Flow

Push → inbox + system notification → tap



Grouping chat messages



50.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.notifications`.

50.7.1 Channels created at startup (idempotent)

```
@Singleton
class ChannelInitializer @Inject constructor(@ApplicationContext private val ctx: Context) {
    fun createChannels() {
        if (Build.VERSION.SDK_INT < Build.VERSION_CODES.O) return
        val mgr = ctx.getSystemService(NotificationManager::class.java)
        // Channel groups (e.g., per account, Ch 42) optional.
        val channels = listOf(
            channel(CH_TRANSACTIONAL, "Order & account", NotificationManager.IMPORTANCE_HIGH),
            channel(CH_CHAT, "Messages", NotificationManager.IMPORTANCE_HIGH),
            channel(CH_PROMOS, "Promotions", NotificationManager.IMPORTANCE_LOW),  // user can
mute separately
        )
        mgr.createNotificationChannels(channels)   // idempotent; existing channels untouched
(user owns importance)
    }
    private fun channel(id: String, name: String, importance: Int) =
        NotificationChannel(id, name, importance).apply { lockscreenVisibility =
Notification.VISIBILITY_PRIVATE }
}
// Called from Application.onCreate / App Startup (Ch 45).
```

50.7.2 Central Notifier (channel/style/group/privacy/PendingIntent)

```
@Singleton
class Notifier @Inject constructor(
    @ApplicationContext private val ctx: Context,
    private val deepLinks: DeepLinkFactory,   // Ch 52
) {
    private val nm = NotificationManagerCompat.from(ctx)

    fun notifyFor(item: InboxItem) {
        if (!nm.areNotificationsEnabled()) return   // permission off (Ch 51) -> inbox still has
it
        val channel = channelFor(item.type)
        val contentPI = deepLinks.pendingIntent(item.deepLink, item.id)  // FLAG_IMMUTABLE,
explicit (Ch 52)
        val builder = NotificationCompat.Builder(ctx, channel)
            .setSmallIcon(R.drawable.ic_notification)
            .setContentTitle(item.title)
            .setContentText(item.body)
            .setStyle(NotificationCompat.BigTextStyle().bigText(item.body))
            .setContentIntent(contentPI)
            .setAutoCancel(true)                      // tap dismisses
            .setVisibility(NotificationCompat.VISIBILITY_PRIVATE)
            .setPublicVersion(publicVersion(item))    // lock-screen privacy (Ch 28)
            .setGroup(groupFor(item.type))            // grouping
            .addAction(markReadAction(item.id))       // action button
        nm.notify(item.id.hashCode(), builder.build())
        postGroupSummaryIfNeeded(groupFor(item.type), channel)
    }

    fun cancel(id: String) = nm.cancel(id.hashCode())

    private fun channelFor(type: String) = when (type) {
        "chat_message" -> CH_CHAT; "price_drop" -> CH_PROMOS; else -> CH_TRANSACTIONAL
    }
    private fun groupFor(type: String) = "group_$type"
}
```

50.7.3 Inbox as offline-first (Room SSOT + read sync)

```
@Entity(tableName = "inbox")
data class InboxItem(
    @PrimaryKey val id: String, val type: String, val title: String, val body: String,
    val deepLink: String, val isRead: Boolean, val createdAt: Long, val account: String,
)

@Dao interface InboxDao {
    @Query("SELECT * FROM inbox WHERE account = :acct ORDER BY createdAt DESC")
    fun observe(acct: String): Flow<List<InboxItem>>
    @Query("UPDATE inbox SET isRead = 1 WHERE id = :id") suspend fun markRead(id: String)
    @Upsert suspend fun upsert(item: InboxItem)
}

@Singleton
class InboxRepository @Inject constructor(
    private val dao: InboxDao, private val syncRepo: SyncRepository,  // Ch 32
    private val activeAccount: ActiveAccountProvider,                 // Ch 42
) {
    fun observe() = dao.observe(activeAccount.require().id)
    suspend fun upsert(item: InboxItem) = dao.upsert(item)
    suspend fun markRead(id: String) {
        dao.markRead(id)                // SSOT update -> UI reflects immediately (Ch 3)
        syncRepo.pushReadState(id)      // sync read across devices (Ch 32, outbox Ch 31)
    }
}
```

50.7.4 Linking: deep-link tap marks read + cancels

```
// In the destination (Ch 52 routes here with the inbox id):
@Composable
fun OrderScreen(orderId: String, inboxId: String?, vm: OrderViewModel = hiltViewModel()) {
    LaunchedEffect(inboxId) {
        inboxId?.let { vm.onOpenedFromNotification(it) }  // markRead(it) + notifier.cancel(it)
    }
    // ... screen ...
}
```

50.7.5 Module structure

```
:core:notifications  Notifier, ChannelInitializer, DeepLinkFactory binding (Ch 52)
:feature:inbox       InboxItem, InboxDao, InboxRepository, InboxScreen/ViewModel (Ch 6)
:core:sync           read-state sync (Ch 32/31)
# Channels created from :app at startup (Ch 45).
```

50.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Duplicate push → duplicate notification	spam	dedupe by stable id (`notify(id.hashCode())` overwrites) + idempotent inbox upsert (Ch 15/49)
Read in-app vs tap race	double mark / stale	idempotent `markRead` ; cancel is idempotent
Read state sync conflict across devices	divergence	LWW/synced boolean (Ch 32/33)
Many notifications at once	drawer flood	grouping (summary + children)
Channel created after first notify	notification dropped	create channels at startup (before any notify)
Account switch mid-notify	cross-account inbox	filter inbox by active account (Ch 42); per-account channel group

- **Stable ids make posting idempotent:** using `item.id.hashCode()` as the notification id means a re-delivered push **updates** the same notification instead of stacking a duplicate (pairs with idempotent inbox upsert, Ch 15/49).
- **Read is idempotent and synced:** `markRead` is safe to call twice (tap + in-app), and read state syncs as a field (LWW is fine, Ch 32/33) so devices converge.
- **Channels must exist before the first notify** — create them at startup (Ch 45), not lazily, or the first notification on Android 8+ is dropped.

50.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Detection	Response	Outcome
User dismisses, loses message	support report	inbox is the durable record (SSOT)	never lost
Notification spam → app muted	opt-out rate	group + correct importance; separate promo channel	retained
No permission (Android 13+)	`areNotificationsEnabled` false	inbox still works; request permission (Ch 51)	data intact
Read state diverges across devices	user report	sync read state (Ch 32)	converges
Notification dropped (no channel)	logs	create channels at startup	shown
Lock-screen leak	privacy review	`VISIBILITY_PRIVATE`/public version	safe
Stale system notification after read	user report	cancel on in-app read	consistent



> **The durable record is the inbox, not the status-bar notification.** Every "lost message" and "read state" problem dissolves once the inbox (SSOT + sync) is the source of truth and the system notification is just a transient, groupable, permission-gated alert that links back to it.

50.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** Central Notifier + channels at startup; basic inbox (Room) written on push.
- **Level 2.** Grouping + styles (Messaging for chat); deep-link tap → mark read + cancel; lock-screen privacy.
- **Level 3 — production.** Inbox sync (read state across devices, Ch 32); permission gating (Ch 51); per-channel user settings + settings deep-link; idempotent dedupe.
- **Level 4 — large.** Many categories/channels with channel groups (per-account, Ch 42); notification preference center; batching/digest notifications; rich actions (inline reply for chat); analytics (delivery/open/mute).
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** Notification governance (which teams own which channels), consent/compliance (Ch 28), cross-device inbox consistency SLOs, A/B of content/ timing, mute-rate dashboards and alerting.

Avoid overengineering: a few well-chosen channels + grouping + a Room-backed inbox with synced read state covers most needs. Don't create a channel per notification or build a custom notification framework over `NotificationCompat`.

50.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
Record of truth	In-app inbox (SSOT + sync)	the system notification	Inbox always (notification is ephemeral)
Channels	By category (few)	one channel / per-item	By category (user-tunable); never per-item
Many related notifs	Grouping (summary+children)	individual notifications	Grouping (avoid spam/muting)
Chat style	`MessagingStyle`	plain text	MessagingStyle (avatars/senders, system-optimized)
Read state	Synced field (Ch 32)	local only	Synced for multi-device; local-only diverges
Lock screen	`VISIBILITY_PRIVATE` + public version	PUBLIC always	Private for sensitive; public only for non-sensitive
Rendering	Central Notifier	scattered `NotificationCompat`	Central (consistency, ids, privacy)

Inbox vs system notification as the record: relying on the status-bar notification as the record loses the message on dismissal and can't show history, read state, or sync across devices. A persisted, synced **inbox** (Ch 3/32) is a durable record that works even without notification permission and across reinstalls; the system notification becomes a transient alert that links into it. Build both; the inbox is authoritative.

Few category channels vs many channels: too few channels give users an all-or-nothing mute (they disable everything after one spammy promo); too many (per-feature or per-item) clutter settings and confuse users. A small set of **category** channels (Transactional, Chat, Promotions) with correct importance lets users mute marketing while keeping transactional alerts — the right balance.

50.12 Security & Privacy Considerations

- **Lock-screen privacy:** `setVisibility(PRIVATE/SECRET)` + `setPublicVersion` so sensitive content (messages, order details, amounts) isn't shown on the lock screen; respect the channel's lock-screen setting (Ch 28).
- **No PII in notification logs/analytics** (Ch 28) — log type/id, not content.
- **PendingIntents `FLAG_IMMUTABLE` + explicit** (Ch 49/52) so other apps can't hijack the intent; validate deep-link targets (Ch 52).
- **Per-account isolation (Ch 42):** inbox filtered by active account; don't render account A's notifications/inbox under account B; per-account channel groups if needed.
- **Respect consent/preferences (Ch 28):** marketing channels honor opt-in; provide a clear settings deep-link (`Settings.ACTION_CHANNEL_NOTIFICATION_SETTINGS`).
- **Don't abuse importance/full-screen intents** to force attention — Play/UX scrutinizes this, and users mute.
- Client vs backend: the backend provides inbox data + read-state sync (Ch 32) and must not include sensitive content in the push payload (fetch over authed API, Ch 49/19); the client enforces channels, privacy,

grouping, and per-account rendering.

50.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **Group and throttle** notifications (summary + children; rate-limit `notify()`) to avoid drawer flood and battery from many posts.
- **Reuse stable ids** so re-delivery updates rather than stacks.
- **Inbox paging** (Ch 13) for long histories; observe with Flow (Ch 3/6) — don't load all rows.
- **Cheap channel creation** at startup is idempotent and fast; don't recreate on every notify.
- **Load notification images** off the main thread with size limits (BigPicture) to avoid jank/OOM.
- **Profiling:** notification post rate, mute/opt-out rate by channel, inbox query cost, read-sync latency.

50.14 Testing Strategy

System notifications test with Robolectric shadows / `NotificationManagerCompat`; inbox tests like any Room/sync feature (Ch 3/32).

```
@RunWith(AndroidJUnit4::class)
class NotifierTest {
    @Test fun `posts on correct channel with deep-link intent`() {
        val notifier = Notifier(ctx, FakeDeepLinks())
        notifier.notifyFor(InboxItem(id="1", type="order_update", ...))
        val shadow = shadowOf(ctx.getSystemService(NotificationManager::class.java))
        val posted = shadow.allNotifications.single()
        assertEquals(CH_TRANSACTIONAL, posted.channelId)
    }
    @Test fun `duplicate id updates instead of stacking`() { /* notify twice same id -> 1
notification */ }
    @Test fun `does nothing when notifications disabled`() { /* areNotificationsEnabled=false ->
no post */ }
}

class InboxRepositoryTest {
    @Test fun `markRead updates SSOT and pushes read state`() = runTest {
        repo.markRead("1"); assertTrue(dao.get("1").isRead);
assertTrue(fakeSync.pushedRead.contains("1"))
    }
    @Test fun `inbox filtered by active account`() = runTest { /* Ch 42 */ }
}
```

What to test: channel creation (idempotent, at startup), Notifier channel/style/group/ privacy + stable-id dedupe + permission-off no-op; deep-link tap marks read + cancels; inbox upsert/observe/markRead + read-state sync; per-account filtering; lock-screen public version. Instrumentation on Android 13+ for permission-off inbox-still-works.

50.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics:** notification post / display / tap / dismiss rates by channel; **mute/ opt-out rate per channel** (the key UX health signal); inbox read rate; read-sync latency/conflicts (Ch 32); permission grant rate (Ch 51); per-account mis-render (0); spam complaints.
- **Logs:** `notif{type, channel, grouped, shown, tapped}` and `inbox{action, synced}` — no content/PII (Ch 28).
- **Debugging:** high mute rate → spam/wrong importance → group + separate channels; lost messages → inbox not persisting; read diverges → sync bug; not shown on 13+ → permission; cross-account render → account filter bug.
- **Alerting:** mute-rate spike on a channel; read-sync failure; any cross-account render.
- **Dashboards:** per-channel mute rate + tap rate; inbox consistency across devices.

50.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥25 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *Two notification systems?* System (status bar, transient) + in-app inbox (durable record).
2. *Which is the record?* The inbox (SSOT + sync); the system notification is a transient alert.
3. *Channels (Android 8+)?* Mandatory, user-controllable importance per category.
4. *Create channels when?* At startup, idempotent, before any notify.
5. *Can you change importance later?* No — user owns it; choose categories carefully.

Rendering 6. *Why a central Notifier?* Consistency (channels/styles/ids/privacy); avoid scattered calls. 7. *Grouping?* Summary + children by group key — avoid spam/muting. 8. *Chat style?* `MessagingStyle`. 9. *Actions?* Action buttons via `PendingIntent` (`FLAG_IMMUTABLE`). 10. *Lock-screen privacy?* `VISIBILITY_PRIVATE` + `setPublicVersion`.

Inbox 11. *Inbox storage?* Room SSOT (Ch 3), synced (Ch 32). 12. *Read/unread?* Synced boolean field. 13. *Survives dismissal/reinstall?* Yes (persisted/server-backed). 14. *UI?* Observe Flow → Compose (Ch 6); paging for history (Ch 13).

Linking 15. *Tap behavior?* Deep link (Ch 52) → screen + mark read + cancel. 16. *In-app read?* Optionally cancel system notification; sync read state. 17. *Read across devices?* Sync the read field (Ch 32).

Permission 18. *Android 13+ no permission?* System suppressed; inbox still works. 19. *Request permission?* Ch 51 (rationale, in-context). 20. *Settings deep-link?* `ACTION_CHANNEL_NOTIFICATION_SETTINGS`.

Security/UX 21. *Lock-screen sensitive content?* Private + public version. 22. *Per-account?* Filter inbox by active account; per-account channel group (Ch 42). 23. *Avoid muting?* Group, correct importance, separate promo channel.

Testing/Production 24. *Test notifications?* Robolectric shadow `NotificationManager`. 25. *Dedupe duplicates?* Stable notification id. 26. *Key UX metric?* Per-channel mute/opt-out rate. 27. *Lost messages?* Inbox not persisting (fix SSOT).

Design-change challenges

1. **Users lose messages when they dismiss notifications.** Build the inbox as the durable record (SSOT + sync).
2. **App is getting muted from chat spam.** Group with `MessagingStyle` summary+children; correct channel.
3. **Promos annoy users who still want order updates.** Separate low-importance Promotions channel.
4. **Read state doesn't sync across devices.** Sync the read field (Ch 32).
5. **Sensitive content shows on the lock screen.** `VISIBILITY_PRIVATE` + public version.

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify (what notification types, need history/read state, multi-device, sensitive?) → two systems (transient alert vs durable inbox) → channels by category at startup → central Notifier (styles/grouping/privacy/PendingIntent) → inbox as offline-first (Room + sync, read state) → link (deep link tap → mark read + cancel; in-app read → cancel + sync) → permission gating (inbox resilient) → privacy (lock screen) + per-account → observability (mute rate).

50.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Create category channels at startup and post an order notification on the right channel via a central Notifier. *Eval:* correct channel; consistent style.
2. **Intermediate.** Build a Room-backed inbox written on push; show read/unread; tapping a notification deep-links and marks read + cancels. *Eval:* durable; tap links + marks read.
3. **Advanced.** Group chat notifications (`MessagingStyle` summary + children) and cancel the group when the conversation is read in-app; sync read state. *Eval:* grouped; read cancels + syncs.
4. **Production debugging.** Fix a high mute rate (split promos into their own channel, add grouping) and a lock-screen leak (private + public version). *Eval:* mute rate drops; no leak.
5. **System design challenge.** Make the inbox work with notifications permission off (Android 13+) and consistent across two devices (read-state sync). *Eval:* inbox functional without permission; devices converge.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

50.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: design **two systems together** — the **system notification as a transient, groupable, permission-gated alert**, and the **in-app inbox (Room SSOT + sync, Ch 3/32) as the durable record** with read/unread; render all system notifications through **one central Notifier** that owns **channels by category** (created at startup, correct importance — users own importance, so don't over-split), consistent **styles** (`MessagingStyle` for chat), **grouping** (summary + children to avoid spam/muting), **lock-screen privacy** (`VISIBILITY_PRIVATE` + public version), and **`FLAG_IMMUTABLE` deep-link PendingIntents** (Ch 52) with **stable ids** (dedupe); **link** the two so a **tap deep-links + marks read + cancels** and **in-app read cancels + syncs read state** across devices; **gate system display on**

`POST_NOTIFICATIONS` (Ch 51) while keeping the inbox fully functional without it; and enforce **per-account isolation** (Ch 42) and **consent/preferences** (Ch 28).

Concepts: system vs inbox, channels/groups/importance, styles, grouping (summary/ children), lock-screen visibility, central Notifier, offline-first inbox + synced read state, deep-link linking, permission gating, per-account isolation.

Common mistakes: treating the system notification as the record (lost messages); no/one/too-many channels; no grouping (spam → muting); scattered `NotificationCompat`; read state not synced (divergence); sensitive content on lock screen; channels created lazily (first notification dropped); no per-account filtering; inbox broken without permission.

Checklist: ☐ inbox = durable record (SSOT + sync) ☐ channels by category at startup ☐ central Notifier (style/group/privacy/ids) ☐ grouping (summary+children) ☐ `MessagingStyle` for chat ☐ lock-screen private + public version ☐ `FLAG_IMMUTABLE` deep-link PendingIntents ☐ stable ids (dedupe) ☐ tap → mark read + cancel ☐ synced read state ☐ permission-gated display; inbox resilient ☐ per-account isolation.

Key APIs: `NotificationChannel` / `NotificationManager.createNotificationChannels`, `NotificationCompat.Builder` / `BigTextStyle` / `InboxStyle` / `MessagingStyle` / `BigPictureStyle`, `setGroup` / `setGroupSummary`, `setVisibility` / `setPublicVersion`, `NotificationManagerCompat.notify` / `cancel` / `areNotificationsEnabled`, `PendingIntent` (`FLAG_IMMUTABLE`), Room `@Dao` / `Flow` (Ch 3), `Settings.ACTION_CHANNEL_NOTIFICATION_SETTINGS`.

References:

- Notifications overview: https://developer.android.com/develop/ui/views/notifications
- Channels: https://developer.android.com/develop/ui/views/notifications/channels
- Groups/stacking: https://developer.android.com/develop/ui/views/notifications/group
- Notification runtime permission: https://developer.android.com/develop/ui/views/notifications/notification-permission
- (composes) Ch 49 Push/FCM, Ch 51 Permissions, Ch 3 SSOT, Ch 32 Sync, Ch 52 Deep Links, Ch 42 Multi-Account

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/class/sequence/grouping/failure diagrams; channels + central Notifier + offline-first inbox + linking code; concurrency (stable-id dedupe, idempotent read, channel-before-notify); failure (lost/spam/perm/ diverge triage); 5 levels; inbox-vs-notification and channel-granularity trade-offs; security (lock screen, per-account, consent); perf (group/throttle/paging); Robolectric
    - Room tests; observability (mute rate); 27 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** push (Ch 49), permissions (Ch 51), deep links (Ch 52), sync (Ch 32).
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥25 bar.